ALLAMA IQBAL OPEN UNIVERSITY ISLAMABAD

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1. A Comprehensive Note on Two of the Following Topics:

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(1) The Concept of Seerat

The term "Seerat" originates from the Arabic word "sīrah," which literally means a path or a way of walking. In the context of Islamic studies, Seerat refers to the biography of the Prophet Muhammad (P.B.U.H.). It encompasses his entire life, including his lineage, birth, prophethood, the revelations he received, his teachings, his relationships with his companions and family, his leadership in peace and war, and the establishment of the first Islamic state in Madinah.

The study of Seerat is of paramount importance to Muslims for several reasons:

- **Understanding the Quran:** The Quran provides the divine revelations and principles of Islam, while the Seerat offers the context in which these revelations were received and implemented. Many verses of the Quran are better understood when studied in light of the specific events and circumstances of the Prophet's life.
- **Emulating the Prophet's Example:** The Prophet Muhammad (P.B.U.H.) is considered the ultimate role model for all Muslims. His life, as detailed in the Seerat, provides a practical example of how to live in accordance with Islamic teachings. His character, his compassion, his integrity, and his leadership are all aspects that Muslims strive to emulate in their own lives.
- **Source of Islamic Law:** The Sunnah, which refers to the practices, sayings, and approvals of the Prophet, is the second primary source of Islamic law after the Quran. The Seerat is the primary vehicle through which the Sunnah has been preserved and transmitted through generations.
- **Inspiration and Guidance:** The Seerat is a source of immense inspiration for Muslims. The stories of the Prophet's perseverance in the face of adversity, his mercy towards his enemies, and his unwavering faith in Allah provide guidance and strength to believers.

The earliest and most famous work of Seerat is "Sīrat Rasūl Allāh" (The Life of the Messenger of God) by Ibn Ishaq, which was later edited by Ibn Hisham. Over the centuries, numerous scholars have compiled and written biographies of the Prophet, each contributing to the rich tradition of Seerat literature.

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(2) Migration to Madinah (Hijrat-e-Madinah)

The Hijrat, or the migration of the Prophet Muhammad (P.B.U.H.) and his followers from Makkah to Madinah in 622 CE, is a pivotal event in Islamic history. It marks the beginning of the Islamic calendar (Hijri calendar) and the transition from a period of persecution to the establishment of the first Islamic state.

Causes of the Migration:

- **Intensified Persecution:** After the deaths of the Prophet's wife, Khadijah (R.A.), and his uncle, Abu Talib, the persecution of Muslims in Makkah by the Quraysh tribe escalated significantly. Muslims faced physical and verbal abuse, economic boycotts, and social ostracism.
- **The Pledge of Aqabah:** Delegations from the city of Yathrib (later renamed Madinah) met with the Prophet at a place called Aqabah. They pledged their allegiance to him, accepted Islam, and invited him to their city, promising to protect him. This offered a new and welcoming environment for the Muslims.
- **Assassination Plot:** The leaders of the Quraysh, fearing the growing influence of Islam, conspired to assassinate the Prophet Muhammad (P.B.U.H.). This made it untenable for him to remain in Makkah.

The Journey:

The Prophet, along with his close companion Abu Bakr Siddiq (R.A.), secretly left Makkah. To mislead their pursuers, they took a different route and hid in the Cave of Thawr for three days. Despite a frantic search by the Quraysh, they were miraculously protected. After leaving the cave, they continued their journey to Madinah, where they were eagerly awaited by the Ansar (the helpers), the local inhabitants who had embraced Islam.

Significance of the Hijrat:

- **Establishment of the First Islamic State:** In Madinah, the Prophet established a community based on the principles of Islam. He drafted the Charter of Madinah, a constitution that guaranteed the rights and duties of all citizens, including Muslims, Jews, and other tribes, creating a pluralistic society.
- **Brotherhood (Mawakhat):** The Prophet established a bond of brotherhood between the Muhajirun (the emigrants from Makkah) and the Ansar, who shared their homes and wealth with their new brethren. This act of solidarity was crucial for the survival and unity of the nascent Muslim community.
- **Beginning of the Islamic Calendar:** The importance of the Hijrat is such that the second Caliph, Umar ibn al-Khattab (R.A.), chose it as the starting point of the Islamic calendar, signifying the birth of the Muslim Ummah (community) as a political and social entity.

2. The Importance of the Noble Character of the Holy Prophet (P.B.U.H.)

The noble character of the Holy Prophet Muhammad (P.B.U.H.) is a cornerstone of the Islamic faith and a source of guidance for all of humanity. The Quran itself testifies to his exemplary character, stating, "And

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indeed, you are of a great moral character" (Quran 68:4). The importance of his character can be understood through the following aspects:

- **A Living Embodiment of the Quran:** The Prophet's life was a practical demonstration of the teachings of the Quran. His wife, Aisha (R.A.), famously described his character as being "the Quran." His actions, words, and decisions all reflected the divine guidance he received, making him the ultimate role model for Muslims seeking to live a righteous life.
- **A Mercy to all Creation (Rahmatun lil-Alameen):** The Quran describes the Prophet as a "mercy to the worlds" (Quran 21:107). His compassion and kindness extended not only to his followers but also to his enemies, to the poor and needy, to women and children, and even to animals and the environment. His merciful nature is a universal message that transcends time and culture.
- **Exemplary in All Roles:** The Prophet's life encompassed a multitude of roles: he was a prophet, a leader, a statesman, a judge, a husband, a father, and a friend. In each of these roles, he exhibited the highest standards of conduct. His honesty and integrity earned him the title of "Al-Amin" (the trustworthy) even before his prophethood. His leadership was marked by justice, consultation, and humility.
- **A Source of Unity:** The Prophet's character brought together a diverse group of people, transforming a tribal society into a unified community (Ummah) based on faith and shared values. His emphasis on equality, justice, and brotherhood broke down barriers of race, ethnicity, and social status.
- **A Timeless Example for Humanity:** The qualities exhibited by the Prophet—such as patience, forgiveness, humility, honesty, and courage—are universal virtues that are admired and respected by people of all faiths and backgrounds. His life continues to inspire millions around the world to strive for moral excellence and to work for a more just and compassionate society.

In essence, the noble character of the Prophet Muhammad (P.B.U.H.) is not just a historical fact but a living source of guidance and inspiration. It provides a blueprint for individual and collective righteousness and serves as a testament to the transformative power of faith and virtue.

3. The Services of Hazrat Abu Bakr Siddiq (R.A.) for Islam

Hazrat Abu Bakr Siddiq (R.A.), the first Caliph of Islam, rendered invaluable services to the faith, both during the lifetime of the Prophet Muhammad (P.B.U.H.) and as his successor. His unwavering faith, wisdom, and decisive leadership were instrumental in the consolidation and early expansion of Islam.

Services during the Prophet's Lifetime:

- **Early Convert and Staunch Supporter:** Abu Bakr was one of the first to embrace Islam outside the Prophet's immediate family. He was a wealthy and respected merchant in Makkah, and he used his influence and resources to support the new faith and to free many slaves who were being persecuted for their belief in Islam, including Bilal ibn Rabah.

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- **The Companion of the Cave:** During the perilous migration (Hijrat) from Makkah to Madinah, Abu Bakr was the chosen companion of the Prophet. He accompanied him on the journey and stayed with him in the Cave of Thawr, an event mentioned in the Quran.
- **Financial Contributions:** He generously donated his wealth for the cause of Islam. On the occasion of the expedition of Tabuk, he famously gave all of his wealth, demonstrating his complete devotion.
- **Leading the Prayers:** During the Prophet's final illness, he appointed Abu Bakr to lead the congregational prayers, which was seen by many as a sign of his succession.

Services as the First Caliph (632-634 CE):

- **Uniting the Ummah:** Following the Prophet's death, the Muslim community was faced with a crisis of leadership. Abu Bakr, with his wisdom and the support of senior companions, was elected as the first Caliph. His inaugural address emphasized his commitment to following the Quran and the Sunnah, and he successfully united the grieving and anxious Muslim community.
- **The Wars of Apostasy (Riddah Wars):** After the Prophet's demise, several tribes renounced Islam, and some individuals falsely claimed prophethood. Abu Bakr took a firm and decisive stance against these movements. He organized military campaigns that successfully suppressed the rebellions and brought the Arabian Peninsula firmly under the banner of Islam. This was crucial for preserving the unity and integrity of the nascent Islamic state.
- **Compilation of the Holy Quran:** During the Battle of Yamama, a large number of Huffaz (Muslims who had memorized the Quran) were martyred. This prompted Umar ibn al-Khattab (R.A.) to suggest to Abu Bakr that the Quran be compiled into a single volume to ensure its preservation. Abu Bakr accepted this crucial task and appointed Zayd ibn Thabit to lead the project. This monumental service ensured that the Quran was preserved in its original form for all future generations.
- **Early Islamic Conquests:** Under his leadership, the Muslim armies were sent on expeditions to the Byzantine (Roman) and Sassanian (Persian) empires. These initial campaigns paved the way for the subsequent expansion of Islam under his successors.
- **Establishment of the Caliphate as an Institution:** Abu Bakr's caliphate established the precedent for Islamic governance after the Prophet. His simple lifestyle, his accessibility to the common people, and his commitment to justice and consultation set a high standard for future Muslim rulers.

Hazrat Abu Bakr Siddiq's (R.A.) two-year caliphate was short but immensely impactful. His leadership during a critical period of transition ensured the survival and consolidation of Islam, laying a strong foundation for its future growth and development.

4. The Causes of Strife and Rebellion during the Caliphate of Hazrat Usman (R.A.)

The caliphate of Hazrat Usman ibn Affan (R.A.), the third Caliph of Islam (644-656 CE), was marked by a period of significant expansion and prosperity. However, his reign also witnessed growing discontent and

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political turmoil, which ultimately led to his tragic assassination. The causes of this strife and rebellion were complex and multifaceted, arising from a combination of political, social, and economic factors.

Key Causes of Strife:

- **Allegations of Nepotism:** One of the most prominent accusations leveled against Usman (R.A.) was that he appointed his relatives from the Umayyad clan to important positions of power, such as provincial governors. While many of these appointees were capable administrators, this practice was seen by some as favoritism and a departure from the practice of his predecessors, who had appointed companions based on their piety and seniority in Islam.
- **Administrative and Policy Changes:** Usman (R.A.) made certain administrative changes that were unpopular with some segments of the population. For instance, he standardized the text of the Quran and ordered the burning of all other variant copies. While this was done with the noble intention of preserving the unity of the holy text, it was misunderstood by some as an innovation and an attempt to control the religion.
- **Economic Discontent:** The rapid expansion of the Islamic empire brought immense wealth. The distribution of this wealth and land became a source of tension. Some of the early Muslim companions who had settled in the conquered lands felt that their privileges were being eroded by the new policies and the influx of new converts.
- **Discontent among the Qurra (Quran Reciters):** The Qurra, who were early converts and had a deep knowledge of the Quran, were influential in the provinces, particularly in Kufa and Basra. They felt that their influence was being curtailed by the central administration and the governors appointed by Usman (R.A.). They became vocal critics of his policies.
- **The Role of Provincial Governors:** Some of the governors appointed by Usman (R.A.), such as his foster brother Abdullah ibn Saad in Egypt and his cousin Marwan ibn al-Hakam who was his secretary, were accused of being high-handed and corrupt. These accusations, whether true or exaggerated, fueled the flames of discontent.
- **The Intrigues of Seditious Elements:** There were individuals and groups who actively sought to undermine the authority of the Caliph for their own political ambitions. Abdullah ibn Saba, a Jewish convert from Yemen, is often cited in historical sources as a key figure who spread propaganda and incited rebellion against Usman (R.A.) in the provinces of Egypt, Kufa, and Basra.

The Rebellion and Assassination:

These grievances, fueled by rumors and propaganda, culminated in a rebellion. Rebels from Egypt, Kufa, and Basra marched on Madinah and besieged the house of Usman (R.A.). Despite having the means to defend himself, the Caliph refused to shed the blood of Muslims. After a prolonged siege, the rebels broke into his house and assassinated him while he was reciting the Quran.

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The assassination of Usman (R.A.) was a watershed moment in Islamic history, marking the beginning of the first Fitna (civil war) and creating deep and lasting divisions within the Muslim community.

5. A Comprehensive Note on the Caliphate of Hazrat Ali (R.A.)

The caliphate of Hazrat Ali ibn Abi Talib (R.A.), the fourth Caliph of Islam (656-661 CE), was a tumultuous period marked by internal conflict and civil strife, known as the First Fitna. Ali (R.A.), the cousin and son-in-law of the Prophet Muhammad (P.B.U.H.), was a man of immense knowledge, piety, and bravery. However, his reign was plagued by the challenge of uniting a deeply divided Muslim community in the aftermath of the assassination of his predecessor, Usman (R.A.).

Accession to the Caliphate:

Following the assassination of Usman (R.A.), the city of Madinah was in a state of chaos. The rebels who had killed Usman (R.A.) were in control, and they, along with many of the senior companions, urged Ali (R.A.) to accept the caliphate. Initially hesitant due to the volatile situation, Ali (R.A.) eventually agreed to assume the leadership to prevent further discord and to restore order.

Key Challenges and Events of His Caliphate:

- **The Demand for Justice for Usman's Assassination:** The immediate and most pressing challenge for Ali (R.A.) was the demand to bring the assassins of Usman (R.A.) to justice. This demand was championed by several prominent figures, including Talha ibn Ubaydullah, Zubayr ibn al-Awwam, and the Prophet's widow, Aisha (R.A.). Ali's position was that he first needed to consolidate his authority and establish order before he could investigate the crime and punish the culprits, as the situation was too chaotic.
- **The Battle of the Camel (656 CE):** The disagreement over the issue of retribution for Usman's murder led to the first open battle between Muslim armies. An army led by Aisha, Talha, and Zubayr marched to Basra. Ali (R.A.) met them with his forces, and despite his efforts to avoid bloodshed, a battle ensued. Talha and Zubayr were killed, and Aisha's side was defeated. Ali (R.A.) treated Aisha with the utmost respect and sent her back to Madinah with an escort.
- **The Battle of Siffin (657 CE):** Muawiyah ibn Abi Sufyan, the governor of Syria and a relative of Usman (R.A.), refused to pledge allegiance to Ali (R.A.) until the assassins of Usman were punished. This led to a standoff and eventually to the Battle of Siffin. After weeks of fighting, when Ali's forces were on the verge of victory, Muawiyah's army raised copies of the Quran on their lances, calling for arbitration based on the Book of Allah.
- **The Arbitration and the Rise of the Kharijites:** Ali (R.A.) reluctantly agreed to arbitration to avoid further bloodshed. However, a group of his followers, who came to be known as the Kharijites ("those who seceded"), broke away from his army. They believed that the decision to arbitrate was a betrayal of the principles of Islam, as they held that "judgment belongs to God alone." The arbitration ultimately failed to resolve the conflict and further weakened Ali's position.

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- **The Battle of Nahrawan (658 CE):** The Kharijites became a militant and extremist group, declaring both Ali (R.A.) and Muawiyah (R.A.) as infidels. They began to terrorize the civilian population. Ali (R.A.) was forced to confront them, and he decisively defeated them at the Battle of Nahrawan.
- **Martyrdom of Ali (R.A.):** The Kharijites, though defeated, continued to be a threat. In 661 CE, a Kharijite named Abd al-Rahman ibn Muljam assassinated Ali (R.A.) with a poisoned sword while he was on his way to lead the morning prayers in the mosque of Kufa.

Legacy of Ali's Caliphate:

Despite the turmoil, Ali's caliphate is remembered for his unwavering commitment to justice, his piety, his wisdom, and his simple lifestyle. He made significant contributions to Islamic jurisprudence and theology. His sermons and letters, compiled in the book "Nahj al-Balagha" (The Peak of Eloquence), are a source of profound spiritual and ethical guidance. His efforts to establish a just and equitable society, in the face of immense challenges, continue to inspire Muslims. His caliphate marked the end of the era of the "Rightly Guided Caliphs" (Khulafa-e-Rashideen).

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